

PREPARATORY ACTIVITY WATCH

Ukraine: Preparatory Activity Watch

10-12 February 2022 | Information available by 23:59Z, 12 February | replay

Analytic state: Watch | AnCR: Low | Change: Broadening multi-domain anomaly

BLUF

We assess it is almost certain (approximately 95% to less than 100%) that abnormal activity is present across several Russian observables with bearing on Ukraine. Targeted public-source collection is needed to distinguish the competing explanations.

Analytical confidence: Low. The information base is incomplete: independent physical reporting is not yet available; official-posture collection is missing; public-reporting series share a substrate.

Source assessment

Source base: Central Bank of Russia funding series, FIRMS thermal-detection series, GDELT-coded public reporting, ICEWS-coded public reporting, MOEX USD/RUB series, NAVAREA warning series, RIPEstat network-prefix series, Sentinel-1 backscatter series, Wikipedia pageviews (public attention). Public-source provenance is not independent verification. Originator reliability, corroboration and misinformation have not been fully assessed; repeated reporting must not be counted as independent confirmation.

Keys: Russia; Ukraine; Moscow; Ukrainian border; Yelnya; Klinty; Belgorod; Valuyki; Boguchar; Millerovo; Dzhankoi

VIIRS NTL 2022-02-10-2022-02-12: not yet available (3-day reconstructed latency).

Assessment

We assess it is almost certain that abnormal activity is present across several Russian observables with bearing on Ukraine.

Russian financial conditions (CBR, Moscow), Russian RIPEstat prefixes, public reporting on Russia and Ukraine and physical activity are simultaneously elevated relative to their recent baselines. The signal is co-movement across those channels.

It is a realistic possibility (approximately 40% to less than 50%) that this reflects reversible preparation, defensive readiness, routine variation or exercise activity. Present reporting does not discriminate among those explanations.

The decision this supports is collection against independent physical posture on those AOIs.

Why this is on the watchlist

Indicator	Observation	Analytic significance
Russian financial conditions	CBR funding spread reached 3.72 sigma on 11 Feb after 2.54 sigma on 10 Feb	Strongest abnormality in the window; unusually large move in domestic funding conditions.
Digital infrastructure	RIPE prefixes remained 2.78-3.14 sigma above baseline for three days	Persistent rather than transient infrastructure anomaly.
Public reporting	GDELT reporting remained elevated; Wikipedia attention rose from 66,480 to 120,857 views	Confirms a heightened information environment; partly dependent on the same public reporting.
Physical activity	FIRMS recorded one thermal detection within the monitored staging AOIs on 12 Feb.	Weak physical indicator.
Maritime warnings	NAVAREA warnings declined from 14 to 7	Does not reinforce the broader anomaly.

GDELT, ICEWS and Wikipedia share a public-reporting substrate.

Competing explanations

Likelihoods use the PHIA Probability Yardstick.

Hypothesis	Likelihood	What would discriminate
Routine variation	Realistic possibility	Anomalies decay without additional domains activating.
Exercise / demonstration	Realistic possibility	Physical activity consistent with announced exercise patterns.
Defensive readiness	Realistic possibility	Persistent posture indicators without further domain broadening.
Reversible preparation	Realistic possibility	Additional independent logistical, financial or spatial indicators.
Preparation for overt action	Realistic possibility	Sustained multi-domain increase plus corroborating physical or official-posture evidence.
Measurement artefact	Unlikely (approximately 25% to 35%)	Anomalies disappear after source or baseline validation.

Collection requirements

1. Physical posture - highest priority. The anomaly is strongest in financial, infrastructure and information indicators. Independent physical evidence on Yelnya, Klinty, Belgorod, Valuyki, Boguchar, Millerovo and Dzhankoi would discriminate. VIIRS NTL not yet available at this cutoff. SAR/backscatter coverage for the last episode day is also unavailable.

2. Official posture. Collect contemporaneous Russian, Ukrainian, UK, US and relevant allied official statements and formal measures, including travel advice, diplomatic drawdowns, defence announcements, NOTAM/NAVAREA restrictions and sanctions measures. Identify changes in declared threat assessment or costly government action.

3. Financial persistence. Determine whether the abnormal CBR funding conditions persist or intensify. USD/RUB data for the last episode day are not yet available.

4. Information-environment composition. Current data establish increased volume and attention, not tone, narrative concentration or source diversity.

Analyst note

Analytical confidence is low. The information base is incomplete: independent physical reporting is not yet available; official-posture collection is missing; public-reporting series share a substrate. The key uncertainty is whether the cross-domain anomaly is a temporary response to the existing crisis environment or the early observable consequences of material preparation.